

User Story Quality Assessment

Feature under review: Car Rental section — New York

Source URL: <https://www.booking.com/cars/index.html>

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1. Scope & Methodology

This document evaluates a representative set of user stories for the Booking.com Car Rental flow scoped to a New York pickup location. Each story is reviewed against seven Agile best practices: standard **As a / I want / so that** format, **INVEST** compliance, **acceptance criteria**, focus on the **Why**, avoidance of technical jargon, supporting **context**, and the team's **Definition of Ready**. Findings are summarised per story with concrete suggestions and, where useful, a refined version and sample Gherkin acceptance criteria.

2. Evaluation Criteria

- **Standard format** — *As a [role], I want [goal], so that [reason]*.
- **INVEST** — Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small, Testable.
- **Acceptance criteria** — bullet list or Gherkin (Given / When / Then).
- **Focus on the Why** — the business or user value is explicit.
- **No technical jargon** — readable by every stakeholder.
- **Context** — designs, business rules, edge cases, related links.
- **Definition of Ready** — criteria defined, dependencies known, no major unknowns.

3. User Story Assessments

User Story #1

Original Story

As a traveller visiting New York, I want to search for available rental cars by entering a pickup location, pickup and drop-off dates and times, so that I can quickly see only the cars that match my trip.

Assessment Summary

Good

Issues Identified

None — story meets all 7 best-practice areas.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Optional: clarify whether 'pickup location' supports airports (JFK, LGA, EWR), neighbourhoods and free-text input.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given I am on the Car Rentals page

When I enter "New York" as the pickup location and select valid future pickup /

drop-off date-times
And I click "Search"
Then I see a list of rental offers available in New York for the selected window,
sorted by recommended price

Given I leave the pickup location empty
When I click "Search"
Then I see an inline validation error "Please enter a pickup location."

User Story #2

Original Story

As a user, I want to filter NY car results by price, car type, supplier and transmission.

Assessment Summary

Needs Improvement

Issues Identified

- Missing the 'so that' part — no business value stated.
- No acceptance criteria.
- 'Filter by supplier' may be too broad to estimate — not **Small**.
- No mention of how filters combine (AND vs OR) — not fully **Testable**.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Add the value: ... *so that I can narrow down offers to the ones that fit my budget and preferences.*
- Split into smaller stories — e.g. one story per filter group — to keep each completable in a single sprint.
- Specify that multiple filters combine with AND, and selections within one filter combine with OR.
- Attach Figma link with filter sidebar mockups.

Refined Version

As a traveller browsing car offers in New York, I want to filter the result list by price range, car type, transmission and supplier, so that I can quickly find an offer that fits my budget and driving preferences.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given the search returns >1 car offer
When I select "Automatic" under Transmission
Then only offers with automatic transmission remain visible
And the result count in the header updates accordingly

Given I have applied multiple filters
When I click "Clear all filters"
Then the full unfiltered result list is restored.

User Story #3

Original Story

As a customer, I want to view detailed information about a selected car — photos, mileage policy, fuel policy, insurance, cancellation terms and the exact pickup address in New York — so that I can decide with confidence before booking.

Assessment Summary

Good

Issues Identified

None — story meets all 7 best-practice areas.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Link the corresponding UX prototype and the supplier-data dependency in the ticket description.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given I am on the search results for New York
When I click "View deal" on a car offer
Then the car detail page shows: vehicle photos, model, transmission, fuel/mileage policy, insurance summary, cancellation policy and pickup address

Given the supplier has no photos available
When the detail page is rendered
Then a generic placeholder image is shown with the label "Image illustrative only."

User Story #4

Original Story

As a registered Booking.com user, I want to complete the rental booking for a New York car by providing my driver details and paying online, so that I receive an immediate confirmation and a voucher I can present at pickup.

Assessment Summary

Good

Issues Identified

- Story is on the upper bound of 'Small' — mixes driver-detail capture and payment.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Consider splitting into (a) capture driver & flight details and (b) payment + confirmation if the team velocity is low.
- Add edge cases for declined cards and supplier API time-outs.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given I am on the booking step for a selected NY car offer
When I enter valid driver name, age, country, flight number and card details, and click "Confirm booking"
Then a confirmation page is shown with a booking reference
And an email with the voucher is sent within 60 seconds

Given my card is declined
When I submit the payment form
Then I see an inline error "Payment could not be processed" and the booking is not created.

User Story #5

Original Story

As a user, I want the page to work on mobile.

Assessment Summary

Needs Improvement

Issues Identified

- No role specificity, no 'so that' clause.
- Not **Estimable**: 'work on mobile' is undefined.
- No acceptance criteria.
- No context: which devices, which breakpoints, which flows.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Specify the persona, the device range and the journeys covered.
- Define measurable acceptance criteria (breakpoints, key actions, performance budget).
- Attach the responsive design specs and the device matrix.

Refined Version

As a traveller searching for a car in New York on my smartphone, I want the car rental search, filter and booking flow to be fully usable on screens from 320 px to 768 px wide, so that I can complete a booking from my phone without zooming or horizontal scrolling.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given I open the Car Rentals page on a 375 px-wide viewport
When I complete a search, apply at least one filter and reach the booking confirmation page
Then no horizontal scroll appears, all CTAs are tappable (min 44x44 px) and form inputs are keyboard-accessible

Given a slow 3G connection
When I open the search results page
Then the Largest Contentful Paint is ≤ 3 s on a reference mid-range Android device.

User Story #6

Original Story

As an international traveller renting a car in New York, I want to view prices in my preferred currency, so that I can compare offers without having to convert USD in my head.

Assessment Summary

Good

Issues Identified

- No explicit acceptance criteria attached.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Add Gherkin acceptance criteria and note the FX-rate refresh frequency — daily/hourly — in the description.
- Make sure the final charge currency at the supplier (USD) is still disclosed at checkout for transparency.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given my account currency is EUR
When the search results for New York are shown
Then every price is displayed in EUR with the daily FX rate, and an info tooltip explains "Final charge by the supplier will be in USD."

User Story #7

Original Story

As a backend dev I want to refactor the /cars/search endpoint to use Redis caching so that p95 latency is under 300 ms.

Assessment Summary

Needs Improvement

Issues Identified

- Persona is the developer, not an end user — no user / business value.
- Heavy technical jargon (Redis, p95) — not understandable for all stakeholders.
- No user-facing acceptance criteria.

Suggestions for Improvement

- Rewrite from the traveller's perspective and treat caching as an implementation detail.
- Move technical notes to the 'Technical considerations' section of the ticket, not the story title.
- Add measurable user-facing acceptance criteria around page load time.

Refined Version

As a traveller searching for cars in New York, I want the search results to load in under one second on a good connection, so that I can compare options quickly without losing patience.

Sample Acceptance Criteria (Gherkin)

Given I am on a stable broadband connection (≥ 20 Mbps)
When I submit a car search for New York with a popular date range
Then the first batch of results is rendered within 1 s in 95% of measured sessions over a 7-day window.

4. Summary Matrix

#	Story Topic	Verdict	Top issue / next step
1	Search cars in NY	Good	Clarify airport vs neighbourhood inputs
2	Filter results	Needs Improvement	Add value, split per filter group, define combination logic
3	View car details	Good	Link mockups + supplier data dependency
4	Book & pay	Good	Cover declined-card and time-out edge cases
5	Mobile experience	Needs Improvement	Define persona, breakpoints, measurable AC
6	Multi-currency pricing	Good	Attach Gherkin AC + FX refresh policy
7	Caching refactor	Needs Improvement	Rewrite from user perspective, drop jargon

5. Cross-cutting Recommendations

- Adopt a single user-story template in Jira with mandatory fields for role, goal, value, acceptance criteria and Definition of Ready checklist.
- Always include the **so that** clause — missing value is the most frequent issue in this batch.
- Keep every story **Small** enough to be delivered in one sprint — split combined flows (e.g. driver details + payment) when in doubt.
- Attach mockups, business rules and edge-case lists to the ticket; avoid burying them in chat threads.
- Replace technical-implementation stories with user-outcome stories, and keep tech notes in a separate section of the ticket.
- Define New-York-specific business rules explicitly (airport pickup, toll handling, NY State age & license rules) as linked context.

Confirm if further adjustments are needed.